

reports. I was among the few who believed in geology. I studied the subject avidly at every opportunity, and applied what I learned to my operations.

The independent operator had to possess a certain amount of basic knowledge and skill. He also needed reliable, loyal and experienced men on his exploration and drilling crews. But, beyond these things, I believe the most

7

important factor that determined whether a wildcatter would succeed or fail — whether he would bring in a producing well or wind up with a dry hole —was just plain luck.

There were some who didn't consider it luck, among them T. N. Barnsdall, one of the great Oklahoma oil pioneers. Multimillionaire Barnsdall often expounded his favorite theory about what he thought made the difference.

"It's not luck," he maintained stoutly. "A man either has a nose for oil or he doesn't. If he does, he smells the stuff even when it's 3,000 feet down!"

Perhaps. But I rather doubt it myself. Personally, I was never able to sniff out the presence of a subterranean oil pool. Nor do I recall that I ever tingled with an oil dowser's extrasensory response while tramping across a potential drilling site. I still think my early successes were due mainly to pure luck.

However, lest there be those who imagine wildcatters had little to do but wait for the wheel of fortune to spin and then reap their profits, let me say that the oil business was never an easy one. It has always entailed work—hard work— and it has always been fraught with innumerable financial pitfalls, especially in the early days. Wells sometimes blew up, and profits—and often capital—were devoured with appalling speed by costly efforts to extinguish the resulting fires.

Dry holes, equipment failures and breakdowns at crucial periods, squabbles and litigation over leases and rights-of-way— these were a few of the